

China

It would come as no surprise that China has been looking into space research from around the same time as USA and Russia. Chairman Mao was the first to recognise the military potential and China had successfully built and tested its first InterContinental Ballistic Missile (ICBM) as early as 1966. Following this, there were a couple of attempts at catching up with the two Cold War nations in the 70s and 80s, but the early spacecraft that China designed never quite worked out.

Bolstered by the strong economy in the 1990s, there was a renewed focus on the space programme. China, in effect, has two major space agencies: the PLA (People's Liberation Army) for crewed and military programs, and the CNSA (China National Space Administration) for civil/scientific



A model of the Shenzhou spacecraft

projects. With the advances already made by the US and Russia, along with China's indigenous Long March rocket that was capable of going into space, it became a little easier to develop the technology needed to send a manned mission into orbit.

The Shenzhou programme was launched with this specific purpose of carrying a 'taikonaut' – a variant of the official 'taikonaut'. Tai Kon, in Chinese, means cosmos. In 1999, an unmanned Shenzhou spacecraft was launched successfully.

The Shenzhou (Chinese for 'divine ship') spacecraft is based on the three-seat Russian Soyuz capsule, although extensive modifications have been made. It consists of three modules: a propulsion section, a conical re-entry